Tradition 1A

By Howard M. Rice

(TIME: 2 AM. Michael is sitting at his desk, drinking a cup of coffee, nibbling on a cookie and flipping through some papers. He is not reading the papers; he is just touching them gently When he recognizes the audiences, he takes a bit of the cookie; considers it, and begins talking – softly, evenly)

MICHAEL: Chocolate chip coconut peanut butter marshmallow molasses . . . my daughter's favorite. *(He takes another bite, a sip of coffee)* She baked a batch before she went back to college. Her favorite used to be macaroon macadamia nut cinnamon banana blueberry, but two years ago chocolate chip coconut peanut butter marshmallow molasses became number one on the cookie hit parade. *(Takes another bite)* She calls them her "Everything but the sink" cookies. Appropriate name. The backer of the cookies in my daughter, Cindy. Senior in college, majoring in psychology. I know parents can be biased – but I truly think she is one of the most special people God ever created. I feel blessed having her for a daughter.

(Picks up a picture from the box) My son Richard. I can sum up my relationship with Richard this way: for years I believed I was Job and Richard was my toughest test . . . somewhere between locusts and boils there was Richard. We struggled through some rough times, we did . . . and for a while I was convinced that either he wouldn't make it to be eleven or I wouldn't make it to be thirty-six. *(Beat)* But he grew up and I guess I grew up too. *(Beat, picks up another picture)*

My wife, Ruth . . . the center of it all . . . the holder together of pieces. I

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love her very much. I tell her as often as I can, which is still probably not often enough. That is my family. *(Beat)* That is my life. *(He puts the picture down, flips through papers in the box again)*

And this is my treasure box -- filled with things I treasure greatly, feelings expressed over 22 years. *(Beat)* A map of our lives in this box. The notes [my family] sent met went into the treasure box in no particular order. *(He gets up, starts to pace.)*

INTRODUCTION

Melanoma is a potentially aggressive, life-threatening cancer. It is readily detectable and usually curable if treated early, but it progresses faster than other types of skin cancer and can spread beyond the skin to affect numerous parts of the body, including the bones or brain. Once this occurs, melanoma becomes very difficult to treat and is incurable.

Matthew Banner has aggressive melanoma. It has spread and it is incurable. But he has a few things to hold onto . . . his family, his treasure box and Tradition – 1A by Howard M. Rice.

MICHAEL: I had been putting the cards in the box for a few years when I realized I had sort of started a tradition. *(Beat)* I never had any traditions growing up . . . unless you call breaking up fights between my mother and father a tradition. My home was like a war zone, and I was always either running away or ducking for cover when my parents fought with each other, sometimes with fists, sometimes with worse. *(Beat)* So I felt good when I sensed that we were creating a tradition. In our own small way, we were building something that bonded us and made us more and made us special. *(Beat. He looks satisfied, smiles, sits down again)* For years that was my only tradition *(Beat)* Then something happened to make me start another one . . .

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building off this one. Tradition 1A I guess you could call it. *(Beat – takes a final sip of coffee)*

I was taking one of my annual physicals with Dr. Jenner. He was listening to my heart through his stethoscope when he spotted a red mark near my collarbone. He sort of poked at it a little and asked me how long it had been there, and I said "how long has what been where?" - I have a lot of freckles so I don't normally notice any little red marks. *(Beat)* He said it looked like a basal cell . . . a form of skin cancer . . . Then he added, "If you've got to get cancer, this is the best kind to get." I thought that was a little like saying, "If you're gonna get hit by a car, a Volkswagen is the best kind of car to get hit by." *(Beat)* He laughed. I didn't *(Beat)* Since then I've had about 25 sores taken off in all – from all over; legs, arms, chest face . . . *(Beat)* After each operation, I felt that something more than a few millimeters of skin had been taken away from me . . . I felt that a piece of whoever and whatever I was had been cut out . . . some of the me in me was gone. *(Beat)* I wanted to replace the part that [had been] subtracted from the outside by adding something to the inside. And so began Tradition 1A *(Beat)* A short time after every operation, late at night when everyone else was asleep, I'd come down to this room, reach into the Treasure Box and take out one of the notes . . . and then I'd read it. *(He reaches into the box, takes out a note)*

My daughter wrote this on Father's Day five years ago. "Dear Dad. What I want to say most to you today is that you are more than a father to me . . . you are my best friend in the whole world. Your loving daughter, Cindy>" *(He looks at the note for a minute, wipes his eyes)* That not put a lot back in

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me . . . . yeah. *(He puts the note back in the box)*

Over the years . . . as the operations became almost routine . . . I got the feeling that the cancers were part of my signature, as if I was somehow identified by them. *(Takes a deep breath)*

And I felt as if I was in a war . . . a war I had the chance to endure . . . to fight and win on my own terms . . . no matter how small the victory. Shoulders back, jaw firm – do not flinch from the needle or knife – ear each scab and scar like a badge. "Where'd you see action, mister? "Valley Forge Medical Building, Suite 202." "Was it bad?" "Yeah, war is hell." *(He stops, looks around. He's embarrassed.)*

The cancer became part of my manhood . . . a part that I hadn't, until then, discovered. The cancer made me more, as it made me less. *(He looks at the picture of his wife)*

Ruth never made me feel less. There were the times we'd be lying in bed and she would gently run her fingers over my body, tracing a path from small scar to small scar . . . certainly an act of loving. *(He takes another note out of the box, chuckles)*

This is one of my all time favorites. My son wrote it to me when he was eleven. He and I had gotten into this thing where we were calling each other Moose. He was Little Moose and I was Big Moose. I think it started when he saw me lifting weights down in the basement. So a week later, I got this note: "Dear Big Moose. I am very impressed with your upper body

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strength. I think you can kick King Kong's ass. Signed, Little Moose." *(laughs)* Pretty big deal when your son tells you you could kick King Kong's ass. *(Beat – almost to himself)* He had a sense of humor. I wished I had sensed that sooner. *(He takes a deep breath)* Anyway . . . *(Gets us, starts pacing)* . . . it went on like that for years. Dr. Jenner would take something off . . . I'd come down here and put something back in . . . replenish myself.

It was a Wednesday night and I was Dr. Jenner's last patient. As I was getting up from the table after he'd taken something off my shoulder. I felt him touch the back of my neck. "How long's tat been there?" he said in a voice I had never heard before. He looked longer and harder at whatever was on my neck than he had ever looked before. *(Beat)* Then I learned that I had more than the VW of all cancers . . . this time it was more like a Mack truck . . . melanoma . . . I'd have six months. *(Beat)*

When I got home, I went right to the Treasure Box. I remember the first note I picked out was the one from Richard about kicking King Kong's ass. *(Beat)* Forty-eight-year-old men with melanomas are in no condition to kick anybody's ass, let along King Kong;s. *(Beat)*

I never thought about dying much. Just a little maybe, like I guess everyone does. But I never feared death. *(Beat)* I have asked to be buried in a cemetery near this house . . . it has lots of trees. I love trees. I have willed that they should take from my body whatever parts might help somebody else. *(Beat)* Cremate the rest. *(Beat)* Then buy the box under a white birch tree. There will be a place for Ruth next to me.

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And I have put in writing that I want my Treasure Box to be buried with me. I want its ashes to be mixed with mine.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
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